

How long should a movie stay in theaters?

Cinemas renew call for time before films stream. But it may be too late to turn back.

By SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

An age-old debate has roared back to the forefront in Hollywood.

The so-called theatrical window has long been a hot topic for studios and movie theater owners. The discussion about how long a film is in movie theaters before it's available for home viewing ramped up during the pandemic, when some studios dramatically shortened their windows before releasing movies for video on demand and streaming.

Then top theater lobbyist Michael O'Leary threw down an unexpected gauntlet.

Speaking before thousands of theater operators and film business professionals in Las Vegas, he called on the industry to establish a new standard: Make viewers wait longer — at least 45 days — to watch movies on the couch.

"A clear, consistent starting point is necessary to affirm our collective commitment to theatrical exclusivity and to provide clear expectations for movie fans," said O'Leary, president and chief executive of the Cinema United trade group, in a speech this month at the CinemaCon trade convention at Caesars Palace. "We cannot sacrifice long-term success for short-term gain."

After that, the topic dominated the convention — and industry chatter. From private conversations to public proclamations, everyone, it seemed, had an opinion on theatrical windows.

Before COVID-19, the wait was often as long as 90 days. Theaters would loudly protest any attempts to shrink windows, until the pandemic and resulting theater closures forced the issue. Chains such as AMC and Cinemark reluctantly accepted the new realities through deals with the studios.

Now the average is around 30 days.

Andrew Cripps, Walt Disney Studios' head of theatrical distribution, told an audience at CinemaCon that the company's films were in theaters longer than those of [See Theaters, A9]



BRENDAN SMIALOWSKI AFP/Getty Images

PRESIDENT Nayib Bukele of El Salvador meets with President Trump in the Oval Office. Neither Trump nor his attorney general asked Bukele to release Kilmar Abrego Garcia of Maryland from a Salvadoran prison.

Salvadoran president says he won't return deportee

Trump officials aren't helping the wrongly expelled man

By FAITH E. PINHO, DAVID G. SAVAGE AND KATE LINTHICUM

WASHINGTON — El Salvador President Nayib Bukele said he would not return to the United States a man who was wrongly deported by the Trump administration, despite a Supreme Court ruling that said the U.S. should take steps to facilitate his return.

Kilmar Abrego Garcia, 29, had lived in the U.S. for 14 years before the Trump administration deported him — an act White House officials called an "administrative error."



NATHAN HOWARD Associated Press

PROTESTERS in D.C. demonstrate against the visit by the self-described "world's coolest dictator."

Although U.S. officials acknowledge he was wrongly deported, they now contend that forcing his return would interfere with El Salvador's sovereignty.

"This is up to El Salvador to return him," U.S. Atty. Gen. Pam Bondi said Monday at the White House, where President Trump and Bukele met with other officials. Neither Bondi nor Trump asked Bukele, who was sitting a few feet away in the Oval Office, to return the wrongly deported man.

Asked by a reporter if he [See Deportee, A5]

California truckers' dispute leads to murder-for-hire plot with a twist

By NOAH GOLDBERG

Aman Singh had much to consider as he lay in the dirt of a Central Valley almond orchard, his flesh caked in a moulage of blood and bruises.

Mostly he was angry at the men the FBI said wanted him brutalized.

Singh's face looked swollen and one of his eyes blackened. Dark red scratches covered his arm.

But the wounds weren't that bad, considering none of them was real — just a couple hours' work by a San Francisco makeup artist.

As FBI agents crowded around him snapping photos, Singh was happy to help stage the fake assault. He hoped it would help federal agents ensnare the men accused of plotting his beating.

But as bizarre as this scene was — a fake assault staged by law enforcement — it was only part of a much broader war between truckers and real estate developers in the Central Valley, former friends turned enemies on opposite sides of a legal battle that turned violent and led to what federal prosecutors charged was a murder-for-hire plot.

"They were going to cut him up and put him in a suitcase," Singh told The Times, referring to the alleged plot to kill a friend of his.

It all started with a fight over a planned truck depot, according to the criminal charges.

In October 2021, Sukhwant Singh — no relation to Aman Singh — purchased a 22-acre empty lot off bustling Interstate 5, in Stockton, for \$2.6 million. [See Plot, A7]

COLUMN ONE

Pali High journalists cover story of their lifetime

Students face myriad challenges as they report on aftermath of fire that damaged school

By BILL SHAIKIN

In a year in which the hometown team is the defending World Series champion, its manager stopped by one afternoon to visit with the high school baseball team.

The national media took note. The neighborhood newspaper chronicled the event. Photographs spread rapidly across social media.

However, on the day the Dodgers' Dave Roberts delivered his pep talk to the Palisades High baseball team, the school newspaper

was not there to cover it.

The staffers of the Tideline — the student newspaper at Palisades Charter High School — are living through the story of their lives. The Palisades wildfire destroyed their newsroom, damaged the school and decimated the surrounding village.

The Dave Roberts story would have to wait. There were more urgent stories to tell.

Two weeks after the fire first roared, with the school closed indefinitely and classes shifted to Zoom, the Tideline staff met for its first

planning meeting of the new semester. The co-sports editor delivered a heartfelt farewell; he had enrolled in another school. Three other journalism students left too.

One Tideline staffer moved in temporarily with Cloe Nourparvar, one of three editors in chief. Audrey Smith, the managing editor, shuffled with her family from one hotel to another, then to a home in the Coachella Valley for a week, and most recently to an Airbnb property.

"We have it for a month," Smith said in an interview, [See Journalists, A12]



GINA FERAZZI Los Angeles Times

SENIOR Cloe Nourparvar, one of three editors in chief of Tideline, reviews her paper's online content.

U.S. tariff reprieve for tech firms may not last

Commerce secretary says such levies would be made through a different mechanism.

By MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — American technology companies hoping for relief from President Trump's trade war with China grappled with further uncertainty Monday, left to decipher whether a government policy exempting businesses that are core to the U.S. economy from crippling tariffs could be relied upon.

An industry that plans product launches and manufacturing years in advance faced four days of vacillation from the White House, which appeared torn over how much assistance to provide U.S. companies that make the nation's smartphones and watches, computers, tablets and semiconductors.

Within the administration, concern had begun to percolate over projected price increases for popular American products, such as the iPhone, which analysts said could triple in cost if Apple were forced in a trade war to manufacture the devices at home. An announcement Friday, exempting technology products from most of Trump's tariff hike of 145% on imports from China, was meant to buy companies time to prepare, according to an official familiar with the matter.

But it also reinforced a reliance on Chinese manufacturing that has driven Trump's aggressive trade policies in the first place, prompting him to vow, in one form or another, to onshore some of the industry's most complicated supply chains.

The result was a temporary rally Monday for tech stocks on Wall Street, followed by a whimper and a second rebound by the closing bell — yet another day of turbulence in markets that have come to react to the president's every word on tariff policy.

"Look, I'm a very flexible [See Reprieve, A9]

L.A. County faces budget cuts

Hundreds of vacant positions will go unfilled, but no layoffs are expected, official says. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Lakers, Clippers playoff primer

A first look at how the clubs match up against their opponents for series that start on Saturday. **SPORTS, B10**

Film production continues slide

On-location shoot days in L.A. declined during the first three months of the year, a report finds. **BUSINESS, A8**

Weather

Turning sunny. L.A. Basin: 67/53. **B6**

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